

Allergic Reactions and Anaphylaxis - Educational Primer

Educational primer for Medically RAG; not emergency protocol or clinical advice.

Spectrum of allergic reactions

Allergies occur when the immune system reacts to normally harmless substances. Symptoms range from mild (sneezing, itchy eyes, hives) to severe systemic reactions. Seasonal allergy, food allergy, drug allergy, and eczema-related itch are common presentations in educational materials.

Skin signs

Skin findings may include itchy red patches, raised welts (urticaria), swelling (angioedema), or eczematous rash. New widespread rash after a medicine or food exposure should be discussed with a clinician, especially if accompanied by breathing or swallowing difficulty.

Anaphylaxis warning signs

Emergency features can include trouble breathing, wheezing, throat tightness, swollen tongue/lips, repeated vomiting, dizziness, collapse, or a sense of impending doom. This is a medical emergency requiring immediate emergency services. People prescribed epinephrine auto-injectors should follow their clinician's emergency plan.

Practical educational points

Avoid known triggers when identified, read labels for food allergies, and keep emergency medicines accessible if prescribed. Antihistamines may help some mild symptoms but do not replace emergency care for anaphylaxis.